Raise the bar.

FOR A LEADER: A TEAM MEETING, A ONE-TO-ONE OR A KICK-OFF

A case in five moves

1. **Here is why this matters**: our clients wait two days for an answer, and some of them leave.
   Say why it matters. Start with the reason, not with the number.
2. **I'd like us to** **cut** the response time from 48 hours to 24 by the end of the year.
   Give a specific, difficult target. A number and a date. "Do your best" is not a target.
3. This is **a stretch**, and **I expect you to** find ways that I have not thought of.
   Show that you believe in the team. Belief is part of the message. Say it.
4. I want you to **tell me early** if we are **falling behind**. Nobody will be **blamed** for bad news.
   Make bad news safe. Say what will happen when someone brings a problem.
5. Reaching 70% will **count as** a strong result, and we will review it together every month.
   Say how you will score it. Say what success and a miss look like.

TOO BLUNT, TOO SOFT

Say the better version out loud first

~~Just work harder.~~	→ What would it take to reach this target?
~~I don't want to hear excuses.~~	→ Tell me what is **getting in the way**, and I will see what I can **take off your plate**.
~~You have no ambition.~~	→ Where do you want to grow this year?
~~Failure is not an option.~~	→ We may **fall short**. I want us to **find out** early.
~~If you miss it, it's on you.~~	→ If we **miss** it, we will look at it together.

Do not argue. Hear the worry, limit the claim, ask what it would take, and offer something real.

WHEN THE TEAM SAYS IT CANNOT BE DONE

Push back with a question

1. **I hear you**, and it is a big step.
   Hear the worry. Say what you understand before you say what you want.
2. **That may be true for** the full year. Let's start with the first three months.
   Limit the claim. A claim about "always" is almost always wrong.
3. **What would it take** to get there?
   Ask what it would take. A calm question works better than a speech.
4. I can't **add people**, but I can **take the weekly report off your plate**.
   Offer something real. A small, true offer is better than a big promise.
5. **Let's review it** in four weeks and adjust if we need to.
   Set a checkpoint. People accept a hard goal more easily when it has a review date.

A REAL EXCHANGE

Two colleagues, one number

A Forty percent more? That is not realistic. Last year we **missed by thirty**.

M **I hear you**, and it is **a big jump**. **What would it take** to get there?

A Two more people, or fewer reports.

M **Fair point**. I can't **add people**, but I can take the weekly report off your plate. Can we review it in four weeks?

A = analyst, M = manager. Both can be right. Say what you agree with before you add your point.

SAY THE NUMBERS OUT LOUD

Out loud, in English

70%	seventy percent
60 to 70%	sixty to seventy percent
180 teams	one hundred eighty teams
2,874	two thousand, eight hundred seventy-four
48 hours	forty-eight hours

Decimal point, thousands comma: 2,874 is not 2.874.

Family 1 needs to
I'd like you to aim higher. Never "I'd like that you aim higher."

Let, make, have: no to
Let the team choose. Never "let the team to choose."

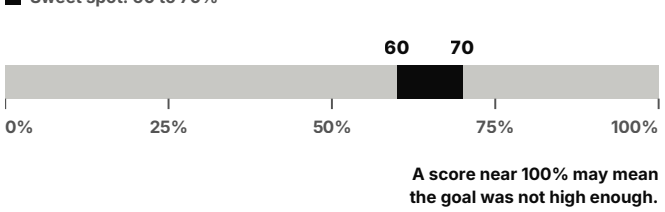
Suggest that + base form
I suggest that she join. Never "suggest her to join."

The not
didn't ask them to start · asked them not to start · didn't let them start · suggest that they not start.

Four levers.

GOOGLE SCALE

Google's scale for an ambitious objective



Each objective is scored from 0 to 1, shown here as 0 to 100%. The score is the share of the objective the team reached: 100% means all of it. Google re:Work, Set goals with OKRs.

NUMBERS YOU CAN QUOTE

With the source

35 years	of research on goal setting: specific, difficult goals **consistently** led to higher performance than **urging** people to **do your best**. Locke and Latham, American Psychologist, 2002
180 teams	studied by Google. **Psychological safety** came first of five dynamics. Google re:Work, Understand team effectiveness
60 to 70%	is Google's **sweet spot** for the average score of ambitious objectives. Google re:Work, Set goals with OKRs
87 sources	in a **review** of leadership styles: **transformational leadership** was **linked to** better **outcomes**, and **hands-off** leadership to worse ones. Judge and Piccolo, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2004
17 studies	in a **review** of the Pygmalion effect in management, with 2,874 people. The effect was strong on average and **varied** a lot between **settings**. McNatt, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2000
70%	of the **variance** in team engagement is related to management, according to Gallup. Gallup, 2026 (the page does not give the sample)
Almost 50,000 leaders	were **rated** by about half a million colleagues. Inspiring others was the skill that most **separated** effective leaders from average ones. Zenger Folkman, a consultancy, company data

Meaning, belief, target and safety. Then the warning: use them in doses.

THE LEVERS

What the team asks, and the evidence

Meaning	"Why this goal?"	Commitment grows when leaders communicate an inspiring vision and behave supportively. Locke and Latham, 2002.
Belief	"Does my boss think I can do it?"	Managers' expectations were linked to performance in a review of 17 studies. The effect varied a lot. McNatt, 2000.
Target	"What exactly, and by when?"	Specific, difficult goals led to higher performance than "do your best". Locke and Latham, 2002.
Safety	"What happens if I miss?"	Psychological safety came first of five dynamics in Google's study of 180 teams.
Dose	"How many goals, and how hard?"	Companies in trouble adopt stretch goals and nearly always fail. Sitkin, Miller and See, Harvard Business Review, 2017. Goals should be prescribed in doses.
Fairness	"Who gets the big projects, and who gets the credit?"	Stretch assignments did not benefit every group equally. Gilmartin and others, Harvard Business Review, 2025.

SIX TERMS

The sentence for the meeting

stretch goal	"Let's treat this as a stretch goal: 70% will count as a strong result."
buy-in	"I want your buy-in before I take this to the director."
commitment	"A hard goal only works if the team has real commitment to it."
psychological safety	"Psychological safety means you can say 'this will not work' in this room."
accountability	"Accountability is not blame: we all know who owns what."
milestone	"Let's set a milestone for each month, so we can see progress."

BOSS?

Can you say it at a meeting?

~~Stop being lazy and hit the number.~~	→ **"I need us to reach the number this quarter. What do you need from me?"**
~~Failure is not an option.~~	→ **"We may fall short. I want us to find out early."**
~~I don't care how you do it. Just get it done.~~	→ **"Here is the result I need. How you get there is up to you."**
~~Anyone who doesn't like the goal can leave.~~	→ **"If you think this goal is wrong, tell me why."**
~~You're not paid to complain.~~	→ **"I hear the concern. What would make the goal more realistic?"**

WATCH OUT · FALSE FRIENDS

The word looks Portuguese, but

~~realize~~ realizar	It means to notice or understand. For a goal, say reach or achieve. Say: We reached the target.
~~attend~~ atender	It means to go to an event. For a target, say meet. For a client, say help or serve.
~~assume~~ assumir	It means to suppose something is true. For responsibility, say take responsibility. Say: I take responsibility for the plan.
~~pretend~~ pretender	It means to fake something. For a plan, say intend to. Say: We intend to double the target.
~~compromise~~ compromisso	A compromise is an agreement in which each side gives something up. For a duty or a promise, say commitment.
~~support~~ suportar	It means to help. For something hard to bear, say handle or stand. Say: He cannot handle the pressure.